

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 28

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A retired farmer walks, one last time, through a field that is no longer his.

1

The new fence was already up. I had heard the men hammering at it from across the lane the previous afternoon, and I had not gone over, because I did not yet trust my face to keep its composure. This morning the rain had stopped, the sky was the soft, washed grey of an old shirt, and I had decided, without quite admitting it to myself, that I would walk the field one more time before I taught myself not to walk it at all.

2

The gate, my gate, was now somebody else's gate. I lifted the iron latch the way I had lifted it five thousand times — with the slight upward jerk that only the latch and I understood — and it gave at once, almost gratefully, as though it were still mine. The hinges, which I had oiled every spring for forty years, did not creak. I closed the gate behind me with the same care, and stood for a moment with my hand on the top bar, before I let myself walk on.

3

The field was the same field and it was not. Underfoot the ground was still the ground I knew — soft, slightly sour, with the small flints my plough had turned up and turned under and turned up again over the decades. But in the corner where the old wooden trailer had rusted quietly into the hedge, there was now a square, low, foreign-looking machine, painted a cheerful blue, with stickers on it I could not read from where I stood. I did not go closer. I was not yet ready to look at it directly.

4

Instead I walked, as I had always walked, the long boundary first. There is a post halfway down the eastern hedge that leans, very slightly, towards the south — the result of a heavy bullock, in 1987, deciding it preferred the next field. I had never straightened the post, partly because I could not be bothered, and partly because it had begun, over the years, to feel like an old joke between me and the

field. I touched the post in passing, as I always did. It still leaned. The new owner, whoever he was, would no doubt straighten it. He would not know why he should not.

5

At the far end of the field, near the brook, stood the stand of pines my father had planted the year I was born. They were taller now than any of us had imagined they would be. As a boy I had hidden in them, sulked in them, and, once, kissed a girl in them whose name I have very nearly forgotten. I did not go into the pines. I stood at their edge for a long time, and let the smell of the resin do whatever it wanted to do to me.

6

I had not heard him come up. When I turned, the new owner was standing perhaps ten yards away, with his hands in his pockets and his cap pulled low, watching me without any expression I could easily read. He was younger than I had feared. He nodded once, civilly, and said, “Take your time. There’s no hurry.” I did not trust myself to thank him, so I only nodded back. After a moment, very quietly, he added, “My grandfather farmed up the valley. I know what a last walk feels like.”

7

We did not say anything else. He turned and went back towards his blue machine, and I walked, slowly, the rest of the boundary I had walked all my life. The leaning post leaned. The pines kept their counsel. When I reached the gate, I lifted the latch with the small upward jerk, closed it behind me, and did not look back. There is a kind of pride, I think, that is quieter than most people imagine. It does not need an audience. It only needs to know, as it walks away, that the field was tended well, and that someone, somewhere, understood what it cost to leave.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says he “did not yet trust [his] face to keep its composure.” Explain, in your own words, what this tells us about his feelings the previous afternoon. [2]

2. The narrator describes his decision to walk the field as something he made “without quite admitting it to myself.” What does this phrase suggest about his state of mind? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator writes that the gate “gave at once, almost gratefully, as though it were still mine.” Explain how this language reflects the narrator’s emotional attachment to the field. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. Give **two** details from Paragraph 3 that show the narrator’s **unease** with the changes that have already been made to the field. [2]

From Paragraph 4

5. The narrator says the leaning post “had begun, over the years, to feel like an old joke between me and the field.”

(a) What does this suggest about his **relationship** with the field? [1]

(b) Why might he feel that the new owner “would not know why he should not” straighten the post? [1]

From Paragraph 5

6. The narrator says he “let the smell of the resin do whatever it wanted to do to me.” Explain how the language of this sentence conveys the narrator’s emotional state. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

From Paragraph 6

7. Give **one** detail from Paragraph 6 that shows the new owner is being **respectful** of the narrator. [1]

8. What is **unexpected** about the new owner’s behaviour, and why does it matter to the narrator? [2]

From Paragraph 7

9. The narrator writes that “the pines kept their counsel.” Explain what this phrase suggests. [1]

10. The narrator says, “There is a kind of pride, I think, that is quieter than most people imagine.” What does this tell us about how the narrator views his own feelings at the end of the walk? [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on why public trust in weather forecasts has fallen, even as forecasts have become more accurate.

1

There is a curious paradox at the heart of modern meteorology. By almost every measurable standard, weather forecasts have never been better. A five-day forecast issued today is, on average, as accurate as a one-day forecast was in the 1980s; satellite coverage is global, models are run on supercomputers, and warnings for hurricanes and heatwaves are issued days, sometimes weeks, in advance. Yet ask the average commuter what they think of the forecast, and the answer is unlikely to be flattering. Trust, by every survey that bothers to measure it, has slipped — and, in some countries, slipped sharply.

2

Part of the problem is that human memory is asymmetric. A forecast that proves correct is rarely remembered; the umbrella stays in the bag and the day passes without comment. A forecast that proves wrong, on the other hand — a downpour that ruined a wedding, a “clear weekend” that arrived as a thunderstorm — lodges itself in the mind for years. The brain, in short, keeps the misses and discards the hits. Even a forecast that is right ninety per cent of the time will, in time, feel suspect, because the ten per cent of failures are the only data points that the public retains.

3

The problem has been compounded, in the last decade, by the rise of dramatic forecasting. Cable channels and social-media accounts, competing for attention in an increasingly crowded landscape, have learned that fear is a more reliable driver of viewership than mild accuracy. A storm that, in the careful language of an official agency, has “a thirty per cent chance of producing localised flooding” becomes, on a viral graphic, a “MEGASTORM” or a “BOMB CYCLONE” set to “OBLITERATE” the eastern seaboard. When the storm arrives as a brisk afternoon shower, viewers do not blame the influencer. They blame the forecast.

4

Behind much of this confusion lies a deeper communication problem: the difference between probabilistic and certain language. When a meteorologist says there is “a forty per cent chance of rain”, she means, technically, that on forty out of one hundred similar atmospheric days it would rain at some point within the forecast area. Most listeners do not hear this. They hear, instead, a simpler binary: it will rain, or it will not. If the day stays dry, they conclude that the forecaster was wrong — although the forecaster was, in fact, right precisely because she did not promise rain.

5

Meteorologists themselves have begun to acknowledge this gap. A 2021 review by the United States National Weather Service found that fewer than one in three members of the public correctly interpreted a stated “probability of precipitation” figure. Worse, those who misunderstood the figure most badly were also the most confident in their interpretation. The result is a steady drift, over years, of forecasts being judged unfairly: the science behind them improves, but the audience grades them against a standard they have constructed for themselves.

6

What, then, might better communication look like? Researchers at the University of Reading have argued for a fundamental shift in vocabulary. Instead of “there is a forty per cent chance of rain”, a forecaster might say “if today were repeated a hundred times, on forty of those days it would rain.” A small change, perhaps, but tests showed that listeners who heard the rephrased version were nearly twice as likely to interpret the forecast correctly, and significantly less likely to feel that the forecaster had “got it wrong”

when the day turned out dry. Other agencies have experimented with visual aids — coloured ribbons showing the range of possible outcomes, rather than a single bold line — with similar results.

7

None of this will silence the morning commuter who is convinced, against all evidence, that the forecast is a fairground trick. But it suggests something hopeful: that trust, like the weather itself, is not a fixed and unmovable thing. It is built, slowly, out of small accuracies, plain language, and the willingness of forecasters to admit, openly, what they do not yet know. The age of the confident, godlike weatherman, pointing at a map and promising sunshine, has passed. What replaces it, if we are patient, may be something more honest — and, in the end, a great deal more useful.

From Paragraph 1

12. According to Paragraph 1, give **two** pieces of evidence that show that weather forecasts have improved over recent decades. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. The writer says that “human memory is asymmetric.” Explain, in your own words, what he means by this in the context of weather forecasts. [2]

14. Why, according to Paragraph 2, will “even a forecast that is right ninety per cent of the time... in time, feel suspect”? Answer in your own words. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. Give **two** details from Paragraph 3 that show how dramatic forecasters distort the language of official weather agencies. [2]

16. The writer says that when an exaggerated storm fails to arrive, “viewers do not blame the influencer. They blame the forecast.” What does this suggest about how the public responds to weather predictions? [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. Explain, in your own words, the difference between **probabilistic** and **certain** language as described in Paragraph 4. [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer says that those who misunderstood the rainfall figure “most badly were also the most confident in their interpretation.” Why is this finding particularly worrying? [2]

From Paragraph 6

19. According to Paragraph 6, give **two** ways meteorologists have tried to improve how forecasts are communicated. [2]

From Paragraph 7

20. The writer says that “the age of the confident, godlike weatherman... has passed.” What is the writer’s **tone** in this sentence? [1]

21. The writer ends the article by saying that what replaces the old style of forecasting “may be something more honest — and, in the end, a great deal more useful.” Explain what is **effective** about ending the text in this way. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **why public trust in weather forecasts has fallen** and **what meteorologists are doing to improve how forecasts are communicated**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Public trust in forecasts has fallen because ...

— END OF PAPER —